CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Antisemitism in Turkey during Operation Protective Edge

Efrat Aviv

It is very clear that under AKP rule, antisemitism has escalated in Turkey, reaching a new peak during Operation Protective Edge, which commenced in July 2014.

Turkish antisemitism is by no means a new phenomenon.[1] Unlike the past, when antisemitism was mainly expressed by AKP members and supporters, the attacks on Israel now echoed through all parts of Turkish politics during Operation Protective Edge. Members of the opposition Kemalist party CHP, for example, applied to the Turkish Ministry of Foreign Affairs in order to establish a group of CHP members to be convoyed to Gaza in support of the Palestinian people. Vice-Chair of CHP Veli Ağbaba appeared on the television program *Siyaset Vitrini* (Window to politics), saying,

> our work is not done by explaining, we want to present our help in an open and sincere way. This is how we will express our solidarity with the Palestinian people who are under constant bombardment. . . . [W]hatever the risk, we will go to Gaza, we will give the people of Gaza moral support, and we will visit the injured in the hospitals. We will show the entire world that we support them.[2]

In addition, CHP chair Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu stated that if the events in Gaza continued, Turkey would be obligated to cease its relations with Israel.[3]

It should be noted that these political leaders and their party's candidate for the Turkish presidency, Ekmeleddin İhsanoğlu, clearly intended their remarks to win votes. This is why Ekmeleddin İhsanoğlu stated that Turkey could not be neutral and remain silent regarding "Israeli aggression" in Gaza, although he had said quite the opposite some time before.[4]

Even at the virulently anti-Israel protest in front of the Israeli Embassy, in which AKP parliament members participated, CHP members were also present. Mahmut Tanal, the Istanbul representative, ranted that Israel is a criminal state that should learn a lesson, and "[w]e stand with the Palestinian

Copyright © 2016. Nebraska. All rights reserved.

Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,